with the Chinese Communists."[18] FEA chief Walter Robertson then suggested that if the communists insisted on India as a neutral, the US could insist that it play that role with Switzerland or Sweden. But General J. Lawton Collins, US Army chief of staff, said a two-nation commission was impractical, and he favored India as a neutral, capable Asian state.[19]

The US soon found its hands tied. A communist proposal on May 7 envisioned a Neutral Nations Repatriation Commission (NNRC) with Sweden, Switzerland, Poland, and Czechoslovakia, as well as India as the chair. Despite pressure from South Korean leader Syngman Rhee to exclude India and Clark's concerns about it having the swing vote, Robertson realized the US had been put in a spot—the communists would use any US exclusion of India for propaganda purposes. Along with pressure from NATO allies, especially Britain, this left the administration with little choice but to accept Indian chairmanship of the commission.[20]

In a twist, the US then backed India for a crucial role that Delhi was reluctant to play. A May 13 UN Command proposal envisioned only India —and not every commission member—as having troops on the ground to supervise the POW repatriation process. For Nehru, the UN Command proposal was "most unhelpful." Zhou told Indian ambassador to China N. Raghavan it was unacceptable, being too much of a departure from the Chinese proposal.[21] Nehru did not want India to take on any responsibility that did not also have Beijing's buy-in.[22] The UNC revised its proposal, but, resisting a Chinese demand, still insisted that India have sole military supervisory authority.[23] Nehru did not think China would agree. Its eventual acquiescence led the prime minister to praise Beijing's "very statesmanlike attitude."[24] He noted publicly that China could now return to nation-building, which had been disrupted by a war in which it had been reluctantly "brought … in" by the fear of US attack.[25]

Nehru's tendency to give China credit and the benefit of the doubt created resentment among American officials. But he was not above giving the US the benefit of the doubt at times. When Rhee released North Korean prisoners instead of turning them over to the NNRC—a move that threatened to torpedo the Korean settlement—Nehru told Raghavan that the Eisenhower administration had not incited the move.[26] With Zhou accusing the US of being "undependable," Nehru suggested that Washington take steps to assure Beijing that it could control the situation. Simultaneously, he